

A Brief History of Space Exploration

The Early Years

The space age began on October 4, 1957, when the Soviet Union launched Sputnik 1, the first artificial satellite. The small metal sphere orbited Earth every 96 minutes and transmitted radio pulses for 21 days.

In April 1961, Yuri Gagarin became the first human in space aboard Vostok 1, completing one orbit of Earth in 108 minutes. Just weeks later, Alan Shepard became the first American in space.

The Moon Landing

On July 20, 1969, Apollo 11 astronauts Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin landed on the Moon while Michael Collins remained in lunar orbit. Armstrong's first step was watched by an estimated 600 million people worldwide.

Between 1969 and 1972, six Apollo missions landed twelve astronauts on the lunar surface. They collected about 382 kilograms of Moon rocks and soil samples.

Mission	Year	Achievement
Sputnik 1	1957	First satellite
Vostok 1	1961	First human in space
Apollo 11	1969	First Moon landing
Perseverance	2021	Mars sample collection

The Space Shuttle and ISS

NASA's Space Shuttle program flew 135 missions between 1981 and 2011. The International Space Station, a joint project of NASA, Roscosmos, ESA, JAXA, and CSA, has been continuously occupied since November 2000.

Mars Exploration

Robotic rovers have transformed our understanding of Mars. Curiosity landed in Gale Crater in August 2012, and Perseverance landed in Jezero Crater in February 2021, carrying the Ingenuity helicopter, the first aircraft to fly on another planet.